



Crystal Lake native Stefania Marzella's love of coffee, combined with her entrepreneurial spirit, inspired her to start Sips, a new venture that makes syrups with minimal ingredients.



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SUNDAY, MARCH 9, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Chicago observers relieved a reserved Johnson achieved ‘a draw’ with congressional Republicans



Avoiding pitfalls

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan | Chicago Tribune

During his first year in office, Mayor Brandon Johnson infamously went on the offensive when pressed on his plans to visit the southern U.S. border.

Instead of answering or brushing off questions, the rookie mayor chided reporters: “I have children who attend schools who have soccer games, y’all.”

“Do you understand that you have not had a mayor like me?” Johnson said in the October 2023 City Hall news conference. “I still have a budget that I have to address. And I’m doing all of that with a Black wife raising three Black children on the West Side of the city of Chicago. I am going to the border as soon as possible.”

The anxiety many Chicagoans felt when he accepted an invitation to testify Wednesday before the U.S. Congress on the city’s sanctuary policy — and the relief once he finished — can be traced to earlier interactions like that.

If he reacted as antagonistically to Republican congressmen hoping to goad him into an argument Wednesday, the mayor’s appearance at the House Over-

sight Committee could have gone south fast. But a different Johnson appeared on Capitol Hill to testify in the hotly anticipated hearing on sanctuary policies for immigrants.

The made-for-TV affair saw him stick to a rehearsed script on public safety and investments in Chicago neighborhoods, despite some of President Donald Trump’s most partisan supporters

taking personal shots at him.

By the end of the six-hour hearing, the consensus in Chicago was that the former labor organizer-turned-mayor succeeded where he had earlier stumbled.

“He did what he needed to do, and the main thing was to be safe and not

Turn to Testimony, Page 2

Above: Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson greets supporters outside the U.S. Capitol after testifying in front of the House Oversight Committee on Wednesday during a hearing about sanctuary cities and immigration policy. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Success story or part of a political football?

Some want protection for gray wolves dropped as role of Endangered Species Act examined

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

For three days in 2019, the howls of gray wolf Zeus at Big Run Wolf Ranch in Lockport echoed for miles as he mourned his mate Chenoa, who died from a gastric condition.

“It gives me chills every time we talk about it,” recalled Rainah Runty, the ranch manager, on a quiet weekday afternoon as gray wolves gnawed on beef bones and rubbed their snouts on the fresh snow. She rubbed the goose-bumps prickling her arms. “You

could literally hear the sadness in his voice. It was absolutely heart-breaking, and I think it just goes to show how much of a family unit wolves are.”

The ranch specializes in North American wildlife and seeks to advance conservation through education. The federally licensed nonprofit is home to three gray wolves from the Rocky Mountains region, four British Columbian wolves, a black bear, a cougar, a Canada lynx and a Siberian tiger. Zeus was 11 when he

Turn to Wolves, Page 6



Amow, a 10-month-old gray wolf, is seen at Big Run Wolf Ranch in Lockport on Feb. 12. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Sounding an alarm for public health

5 years after COVID-19 gripped world, some warn of Trump policies

By Angie Leventis Lourgos and Lisa Schencker
Chicago Tribune

The patient wasn’t initially worried when she first caught COVID-19.

Fully vaccinated and relatively healthy at the age of 41, Johanna Claudette of the Irving Park neighborhood thought the positive test in February 2022 wouldn’t be a big deal.

But within days, her memory became spotty. Her heart raced and she became fatigued. Today, she said, she’s still grappling with blurry vision, chest pain and brain fog — all symptoms of the chronic condition called long COVID, which can linger for months or even years after an initial infection and which has afflicted millions worldwide.

Five years ago, reports of the new and mysterious virus emanating from China gripped the globe in terror and uncertainty.

As infections spread across continents, humanity raced to better understand the novel coronavirus and prevent its prolif-

Turn to Health, Page 12

Frustrations expressed to Democratic lawmakers

Those unhappy with Trump initiatives saying something must be done

By Daniel C. Vock and Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

A retired engineer from Downers Grove who leaned liberal but was never overly engaged in politics, Bill Blair has had an awakening since Donald Trump was elected president a second time.

The 70-year-old joined the grassroots progressive group Indivisible and attended a downtown Chicago rally with 1,500 others demanding Democratic U.S. Sens. Dick Durbin and Tammy Duckworth “fight the fight” rather than look for any common ground with Trump’s administration. He also fired off letters to members of the U.S. House, rallied again in DuPage County to protest proposed Medicaid cuts and logged on to a telephone town hall meeting with his congressman, Democratic U.S. Rep. Sean Casten.

“People talk about how Democrats are exhausted, and I get it. But it was a gut punch for both my wife and I,” he said of Trump’s

Turn to Democrat, Page 4



High expectations for the Cubs

Back as division favorites, the Cubs will only go as far as their bullpen takes them. Plus, notables at White Sox camp. **Chicago Sports**

House Republicans have interim budget bill

The bill would provide slight boost to defense programs, while trimming nondefense programs below 2024 budget-year levels. **Nation & World**

